

1920–1929

ROBES DE STYLE

In stark contrast to the streamlined dress of the “modern woman” with its straight lines, often emphasized by geometric decoration, a much softer and more romantic silhouette survived beyond the late 1910s. The most prominent feature of this feminine style was a very full skirt that sometimes required support by the means of side-hoops – stiff understructures shaped like small baskets and worn over the hips. The Paris couturier Jeanne Lanvin is most associated with this type of dress, which was particularly suitable for younger ladies. The so-called *robe de style* was inspired by 18th-century gowns and was more forgiving than androgynous 1920s shapes. The vast expanse of the skirt provided a large, blank canvas that could be filled with embroidery, artificial flowers, lace, and feathers.

DOLLY SISTERS



The Hungarian-born twin dancers Roszika and Janszika Deutsch were known less for their stage act than for their matching outfits, often provided by Jean Patou, and their spectacular private lives acted out on the French Riviera, in nightclubs and casinos. The ostrich feather skirts of their windmill costumes echo the *robe de style* silhouette.

1924

Spangled streamers
provide movement

Low waistline

Embroidered
roundels



Waist at
natural level

1920

Tulle band
softens
neckline

Lace skirt with
black apron feature



Cinderella The French House of Douillet was known for attention to detail and exquisite eveningwear. Andre Marty illustrated this evening dress called *Cendrillon* (Cinderella), which combines soft lace, a colourful band at the hips, and large blocks of austere black.

Short overskirt

Peacocks In the centre of the roundels decorating Lanvin's evening gown, two embroidered peacocks face each other, surrounded by beads, pearls, rhinestones, and spangles. Embroidered tulle decorates the neck and hem bands.

Simple neckline

Silk
appliqué
leaves



Autumn leaves The French couture house Mybor employed artists to create designs for their clothing. Silk autumn leaves, their veins emphasized with pieces of lamé, are attached to triangular panels that fall to the hem of this skirt.